



Da Vinci's design was way ahead of its time

that era, was a robotics pioneer of this time. In 1737, Vaucanson built the Flute player, The Tambourine Player and his most famous work, the Digesting Duck. This bird automaton had 400 moving parts in each wing (an astonishing number for that time) and it could actually flap its wings, consume water and grains and then defecate. This was achieved through a hidden compartment of fake 'digested food'. Such frauds were commonplace around the time as the onlookers mainly viewed automatons as means to entertain.

The humanoids arrive

The 19th century saw multiple areas of progress that made advanced robotics (compared to the impractical automatons of the 18th century) a greater possibility. In terms of theory, it was in 1847 that George Boole represented logic in a mathematical form understandable to machines, which is what we know as Boolean Algebra. The automated Jacquard loom of 1801 and Babbage's